Mason and Dixon, and Picard

Draft slide sentence for the GIS master deck, 9 November 2026

Picard measured France with a chain of triangles; a century later Mason and Dixon stretched chains and ten-foot rods straight along the ground instead, but both did the same thing underneath: turned star angles into miles on a round Earth.

Why this wording. Mason and Dixon did not use Picard's triangles. They measured length directly with chains and rods and got latitude from a zenith sector, a telescope aimed at stars overhead. What they share with Picard is the idea of tying a measured ground distance to a measured angle in the sky, and in 1768 their degree of latitude was set beside the French measures. So the sentence says the idea was shared, rather than that the geometry was Picard's.

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